

TIME IS INSIGNIFICANT, AND NEVER A DIFFICULTY FOR NATURE

EARLY THEORIES OF EVOLUTION

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURES

The Comte de Buffon (1707–88), **Jean-Baptiste Lamarck** (1744–1829)

BEFORE

1735 Swedish botanist Carl Linnaeus publishes *Systema Naturae*, a system of biological classification that later helped to determine species' ancestry.

1751 In "Système de la nature" French philosopher Pierre Louis Moreau de Maupertuis introduces the idea that features can be inherited.

AFTER

1831 Etienne Geoffroy Saint-Hilaire writes that sudden environmental change can cause a new species to develop from an existing organism.

1844 In *Vestiges of the Natural History of Creation*, Scottish geologist Robert Chambers argues—anonymously—that simple creatures have evolved into more complex species.

Before the 18th century, most Europeans believed that plant and animal species stayed unchanged throughout time—a view now known as essentialism. This idea came under challenge as a result of two